



The significance of Leni Riefenstahl (1902-2003)

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Leni Riefenstahl

"I want to see, that's all. This is my life. I want to see." Leni Riefenstahl, a significant individual ~~who greatly~~with great impact~~ed on~~ Germany throughout the 20th century. Riefenstahl, a film director and actress, is accredited with being one of the most controversial filmmakers of the early 1920's. Her visionary abilities resulted in interest from Adolf Hitler and the Nazi party, with her creating political propaganda supporting them. The lasting influence of her innovative filmmaking abilities on modern cinema is undisputed by 21st century scholars and filmmakers, however her involvement with the twentieth century's most reviled fascist dictator remains heavily debated. Riefenstahl, a prominent feminist, is most well-known for her visually eloquent films *Triumph of the Will* (1935) and the two part *Olympia* (1938). Her film *Olympia* was the first to use important cinematic techniques that are prevalent in the cinematic world today, prevailing the way we watch and enjoy sport in the current modern era. Although Riefenstahl had incredible film abilities, her life after World War II was incredibly different, being imprisoned for her Nazi involvement, and then being cleared of collaboration with any war crimes. Her film career was clearly over, every effort to produce another film was shut down. Her documentaries continue to be studied in some film schools, Riefenstahl will forever remain trapped in the shadow of her political past. ~~In an essay titled "The Devil's Director", Robert Sklar summarises the continuous debate surrounding Riefenstahl's films and her involvement with Hitler and Nazi Germany stating, "What may be the most significant controversy in the hundred-year history of cinema: the question of a filmmaker's responsibility for the crimes committed in the name of political ideologies their work has glorified."~~ (Shorten your introduction. You could take this part out and put it somewhere in your body paragraphs.) -Leni Riefenstahl's contribution to the film community is incredibly important in the development of modern cinema throughout the world, however her ties with Adolf Hitler are debated by historians as to if she deserves the credits from her films.

Born in 1902, Helene Bertha Amalie "Leni" Riefenstahl grew up with her brother Heinz. She spent most of her childhood swimming, painting and acting, taking dancing lessons and performing across Europe. Her father was incredibly successful and contributed his money to improve Riefenstahl's talents. When she was 16, she attended her first musical 'Snow White', which interested her so immensely, causing her to choose the career path of a dancer. Her father despised this and instead wanted her to have a 'normal' job, resulting in a falling out in the family. Without telling her father, she enrolled in dance and ballet classes at Grimm-Reiter Dance School in Berlin, improving her skills. In 1924, Riefenstahl suffered a detrimental knee injury which ended her dancing career. She convinced famous filmmaker Arnold Fanck to give her an acting role. She absorbed as much as she could about directing, camera work and editing, hopeful in creating her own films, eventually catching the eye of Adolf Hitler, where her career took off. Riefenstahl's early life played a large influence on her later filmmaking career. She was always incredibly artistic, having interest in films, acting and dancing from a young age.

Leni Riefenstahl is generally regarded as one of the most controversial, yet influential/innovative ~~excellent~~ filmmaker in the history of cinema. She had great visionary abilities and her cinematic abilities play significance on the way we produce and enjoy films

today. Though she enjoyed fiction, she is most recognised for her strength of two classic documentaries, *Triumph Des Willens* (*Triumph of the will*, 1935) and *Olympia* (1938). Although she only made eight films throughout her lifetime, she won many awards and was globally recognised for her abilities. ~~(this could be shortened as you discuss it later on in the paragraph about the movie) Triumph of the Will, Riefenstahl's propaganda coverage for Adolf Hitler and his Nazi party was especially noteworthy. It portrays Hitler as if he was descending upon Germany much like a heavenly god, able to fix all of Germanys problems. It outlines a clear distinction between the masses of people and Hitler, placing him on an ever present pedestal. She filmed him from a low angle, emphasising his power. It gives the impression of world power, prestige, accomplishment and pride of the Nazi party. Although Triumph Des Willens was seen as Nazi propaganda, her film techniques used throughout are categorically influential throughout history.~~ Leni Riefenstahl did not just have influence on the representation of the Nazis throughout this period, she was incredibly versatile; dancing, acting, writing and directing many films that were commonly in the epitome of a 'men's world'. This opened up the filmmaking world for women, making it more accepted for a female to be in charge and involved in a state where women had been treated as the second gender for centuries. Her effect of making it in a men's world inspired many other women across Germany to strive for the involvement in the production of film as she had.

The Summer Olympics in 1936 took place in Berlin, in the midst of Nazi Germany. The *Führer* of Germany was so delighted by Leni Riefenstahl's earlier films, that he granted Riefenstahl the right to produce one of the most expensive films in Germanys history, the coverage of ~~the Olympics~~^{said games}, which Riefenstahl released in 1938, called '*Olympia*'. He believed it would be a meditation on everything the Games stood for and everything that Germany could achieve. David Goldblatt, an avid writer about the Olympic Games wrote in his book '*The Games*', "*Olympia broke the mould of Olympic films in many ways. First, Riefenstahl had a degree of active support from the organizers... that no other film-maker had acquired. She had total access and total control, and an immeasurably large crew and budget. Second, in terms of technological and cinematic sophistication, there was no comparison. This film was designated by American directors as one of the top 10 films of all time, also meriting it with the Grand Prize at the International Film Show in Venice. It was the first documentary of the Olympic games ever and appears on Time magazines "All time 100 movies."* Reifenstahl released *Olympia* in ~~three~~³ languages; French, German and English, which allowed the film to be enjoyed throughout many countries of the world. "I was fascinated by the effects that could be achieved by editing. The cutting room became a magic workshop for me." This was quoted by Reifenstahl throughout her involvement in creating *Olympia*, as she preferred to complete the editing and making of the film by herself. The film is controversial due to its political context, however the techniques used were ground-breaking and play largely on how sports is filmed, produced and enjoyed. Revolutionary techniques that were included by Reifenstahl include smash cuts, extreme-close ups, unusual camera angles and placing tacking shot rails within the bleachers. Perhaps the most innovative, however, was the inclusion of the underwater camera, which was used to film the swimming and diving events. The cameraman would follow the divers throughout the air and then dive under the water with them to follow their movements. Reifenstahl claimed that the film was not related to the Nazi legacy, however the film was prohibited in many countries. Reifenstahl was travelling the United States promoting the film when the truth about Nazi Germany was revealed, and she was immediately asked to leave the country. *Olympia*, despite its clear Nazi involvement, marked an important revolution for the involvement of

women in film, as not many women had had that power before Reifentahl. It also laid the foundation of the future of how sport is enjoyed globally through the use of many film techniques.

"I am one of the millions who thought Hitler had all the answers. We only saw the good things; we did not know about the bad things to come." In 1932, Leni Riefentahl's first major feature film *Das Blaue Licht* attracted the attention of the rising politician Adolf Hitler. The following year, he asked her to direct a short film at the Nuremburg Nazi Party Rally. This film was a precedent of the following years production for one of her more famous films, *Triumph Des Willens*, glorifying another Nazi rally. She shot Hitler from a low angle, placing him in a position of power over the common man, cutting to the cheering crowd out of context to induce the appearance of support. Placing Hitler in this light made him a mighty figure, dominating the frames he is in. This film is regarded by many film makers as one of the most masterful propaganda films ever produced, increasing the support for Hitler throughout Germany. Her techniques used are mirrored in the scenes of military assembly in George Lucas's *Star Wars*, which show the Riefentahl touch. She stated just before WWII: "In 1934 people were crazy and there was great enthusiasm for Hitler. We had to try and find that with our camera." The start of World War II had a detrimental effect on Reifentahl and her career as she began to lose confidence in the ideals she had faithfully supported before the war. She witnessed the execution of Polish civilians for no real purpose, causing her to leave filming that day to make a personal appeal to Hitler against such arbitrary violence. Although the incident planted a seed of doubt in Riefentahl's mind, she had no qualms in filming Hitler's triumphal parade a week later. Reifentahl often denied claims that she was romantically tied with Hitler, stating in 1934 "They kept asking me over and over again whether I was having a romance with Hitler. Are you Hitler's girlfriend? I laughed and answered the same way each time: No, those are false rumours. I only made documentaries for him." Throughout Hitler's career, even though the connection between the two has been debated between historians, no evidence has been found to prove the relationship. The significance of Riefentahl helping Hitler is the increased support towards the Nazi party from civilians after viewing the film. This created a greater backing for Hitler, largely contributing to the horrendous acts he was able to complete. Well done, this argument you present is a great discussion.

Leni Riefentahl's life changed dramatically after World War II. She immediately tried to distance herself with the association of the criminal Nazi party, suggesting she only associated with Hitler for the opportunity to produce films on a large scale. She was subject to four denazification proceedings, finally being declared a Nazi sympathiser. Reifentahl spent a brief stint in German jails for her actions, being held captive by the Allies. She found it hard to secure her place back in the German cinematic community, unable to cut ties with her earlier propaganda film, *Triumph of the Will*. She produced *Tiefland* in 1954, which was ultimately unsuccessful a flop, suggesting her film career was over. This was also due to the ban on producing films in Germany after the war. Following this she began to spend her time taking photos and publishing them anonymously. The mMajority of her life after the war was spent trying to find work again as a director to no avail. Amid widespread criticism, she declared that her films were apolitical, only inspired by her desire to create works of art. "No anti-Semitic word has ever crossed my lips," Riefentahl told filmmaker Ray Muller in 1993.

“I have thrown no atomic bombs. I have never betrayed anyone. What am I guilty of?” Leni Riefenstahl spent 20 years in isolation in her mother’s home in Munich. At 60, she began a series of trips to Africa, documenting, living with and photographing African tribes. Riefenstahl, a tiny woman with fierce determination and physical courage, took up scuba diving. She claimed she was 51, when in fact she was 20 years older, to gain a diving licence. Two collections of her underwater photographs, ‘Coral Gardens’ and Wonders Under Water’ were published anonymously in the United States. She continued diving in the Maldives until she was in her late 90’s. When Riefenstahl was 90, she became centre of heated debate when she was the subject of a three-hour documentary titled, ‘The Wonderful, Horrible life of Leni Riefenstahl.’ She followed this by publishing her own 669 paged memoir, ‘Leni Riefenstahl: A Memoir,’ discussing her filmmaking abilities and her disassociation with Hitler. Coinciding with her 100th birthday, she released her first documentary in half a century, ‘Impressions under water.’ In Germany in the late 20th century it became more acceptable to praise Leni Riefenstahl for her cinematic talents, however in 1975, Ms Sontag, an American writer, filmmaker, philosopher, teacher, and political activist wrote in the ‘The New York Review of Books’ “There is a common aesthetic running through Riefenstahl’s triptych of fascist visuals,” drawing on the connection of her earlier work for Hitler and her later individual work Riefenstahl did not shy from the spot light in her last years, passing away in September 2003, at the age of 101. What do you think? Do you think she enjoyed working with Hitler? Or do you agree that she was just making ‘documentaries’?

Leni Riefenstahl’s contribution to Germany in the 19th century is incredibly debated; however, her filmmaking abilities are influential as to how modern cinema is produced and enjoyed. Riefenstahl, born in 1902, had many important achievements throughout her lifetime, however her ties to twentieth century fascist dictator Adolf Hitler led many to believe she was connected to his Nazi Party crimes. It is likely without Riefenstahl’s films portraying Hitler that he wouldn’t have gained so much support from the nation, largely contributing the Nazis ~~(too emotive)~~ evil actions. Leni Riefenstahl is still seen by many filmmakers as innovative and many of her techniques are implemented in the way we view sporting events. Her coverage of the Olympic games in 1936 sparked an increased interest of watching sport as she filmed it in an interesting way, using Alfred Hitchcock’s famous quote “What is drama but life with the dull bits cut out,” as her method of encouraging attention to her film. She used methods such as the underwater camera to capture the divers under water, a new technique that shocked the filmmaking industry and tracking rails to follow the athletes. Her second most famous film Triumph Des Willens (Triumph of the will, 1935) used propaganda techniques which are still prominently used in the modern era in political instances. Leni Riefenstahl is also accredited with laying the foundation of women in the film industry as before her it was seen as a ‘men’s’ industry. She became involved with Hitler after his interest in some of her films, putting her in the spotlight as she produced propaganda films supporting Hitler and his Nazi Party. ~~Many believed they were romantically tied however she denied this repeatedly.~~ When the truth about the Nazi party surfaced Leni Riefenstahl was immediately jailed, however being released as she was classed as a Nazi sympathiser. This meant her place in the German cinematic world was lost and she was unable to produce another successful film in her lifetime. Her life after this time period consisted of isolation, however producing a memoir coinciding with her 90th birthday. Her films are studied in some film schools to this day. Her involvement with Adolf Hitler is an

issue that will still be heavily debated for many years by historians, however Leni Riefenstahl has an incredible significance on this period in Germany's history, and has a large influence on the way the modern society produces and enjoys film. Try to cut some of this out, it is a long conclusion.

You could also discuss what impact her films had on Germany in general. How was Germany viewed outside of Germany? As these techniques were so innovative, did they contribute to the Nazi's perceived power?

How would history be different if Riefenstahl were not involved with the Nazis? Would their propaganda be as successful? Would her career have been so successful during that time?

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